

Tracing “Moon Jar” Across Museum Sources

How to turn a repeated cultural-history claim into an evidence trail

Prompt

A client encounters the claim that the painter Kim Whanki is connected to the modern Korean name dal hangari (“moon jar”). What can an initial source pass establish, and what still requires primary-source verification?

First-pass evidence

National Museum of Korea curator material states that the large round white porcelain jars were not nicknamed “moon jars” until the 1950s. A separate National Museum exhibition text links the name to Kim Whanki, describing his affection for the jars and stating that he gave them the name “moon jar.” The Metropolitan Museum of Art uses “Moon jar” as a present-day catalogue term for its example.

These records are useful, but they do not by themselves prove an original act of coinage. Two pages from one institution should not be treated as two independent historical confirmations, and current museum terminology cannot establish who first used a term decades earlier.

Source	Recovered claim	Use	Caution
NMK Curator’s Picks	Nickname dates to the 1950s	Terminology chronology	Institutional secondary source
NMK exhibition text	Kim Whanki linked to naming	Lead for reception history	Needs earlier documentary evidence
Met collection record	“Moon jar” used as current title	International catalogue usage	Does not establish origin of term

Next-stage archival work

- Search digitized Korean newspapers, exhibition catalogues, artist writings, criticism, and Kim Whanki-related publications from the 1950s onward for early appearances of 달항아리.
- Capture exact wording, date, author, publication, page, and context rather than saving only modern summaries.
- Distinguish “coined the term,” “used the term,” and “popularized the term.” They are not equivalent claims.
- Build a dated evidence table and stop at the earliest verified usage found; do not fill documentary gaps with inference.

965.8 cm x 76.1 cm, T/white, 2911-0001-0147-Tm/51775F-113 TL (Needs anal
Please do not cite/museum info (1090110147-Tm/51775F-113 TL) as a research sample reproduction or figure

[National Museum of Korea - exhibition text featuring Moon Jar](https://www.museum.go.kr/ENG/contents/E0202030000.do?exhiSpThemId=650179&schM;=relic_view)

https://www.museum.go.kr/ENG/contents/E0202030000.do?exhiSpThemId=650179&schM;=relic_view

[The Metropolitan Museum of Art - Moon jar](https://www.metmuseum.org/art/collection/search/45432)

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Evidence labels used in a client memo

- **Confirmed:** directly supported by a cited record.
- **Institutional secondary:** a museum or scholarly summary that still may require tracing.
- **Lead:** plausible direction for further research, not yet a finding.
- **Unresolved:** evidence gap left open rather than filled by inference.

Scope note

This sample intentionally stops before claiming a primary-source origin for the name. The unresolved gap is the point of the exercise.